CHHATTISGARH

Tribal Talent Hunt

The Khelo India Tribal Games may mark a new chapter in nurturing Adivasi sporting genius

By **Rahul Noronha**

IDENTIFYING SPORTING TALENT AMONG tribals is an idea that has been pursued, with some success, since the Special Area Games project of the 1980s. The Centre has now embarked on a fresh chapter in this initiative, bringing it under the Union sports ministry's flagship Khelo India scheme to broadbase sports. Result: the first Khelo India Tribal Games (KITG) in Chhattisgarh. The event, running from March 26 to April 6, would be an all-tribal competition. And one with a truly national footprint, with as many 31 states and Union Territories sending contingents of Adivasi sports talent.

Spread over three locations in the state—Raipur, Ambikapur and Jagdalpur—KITG 2026 will feature seven disciplines: hockey, athletics, football, weightlifting, archery, swimming and wrestling. Besides, malkhambh and kabaddi come in as demonstration sports. The choice of disciplines was governed by those in which Adivasis have demonstrated talent and excellence in the past.

Takeaways

- **Chhattisgarh hosts the first national tribal sports event under Khelo India**
- **31 states and UTs send teams to a competition meant to identify talent**
- **Completion is timed with the deadline for ending left-wing extremism from state, marking a new chapter**

EARLY HARVEST

What's the idea behind having tribals compete with tribals? The objective is to revive sporting culture at the grassroots, identify talent and build supportive infrastructure. "Tapping talent from tribal regions is key, and continuously expanding our athlete base is the requirement of the hour," explains Union sports minister Mansukh Mandaviya. The event aims to fulfil both imperatives at once, from early talent-spotting to integrating promising youth into "the national sports framework".

Political watchers in Chhattisgarh also see a link between the timing of the Games and the deadline announced by Union home minister Amit Shah to end left-wing extremism in the state. "The event can be seen as marking that social shift," says a BJP leader.

For the past two years, the Chhattisgarh government has been organising a Bastar Olympics. The previous Bhupesh Baghel government, too, had organised 'Chhattisgarhia Olympics'—a pan-state event with the focus on local sports like *gedi* and *pitthu*. For all the political symbolism, the state has not fared too well in sports. In the National Games 2025, Chhattisgarh stood 25th in a field of 37. Perhaps 2026 will help take aim anew. ■



ANI

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

YOU WOULDN'T THINK A MID-LEVEL official could shake up a state government. But Gagandeep Singh Randhawa, Amritsar district manager with the Punjab State Warehousing Corporation, has done just that. Except he had to end his life, and leave behind a video with explosive allegations, to accomplish that. In the political earthquake that has ensued, Bhagwant Mann's Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) regime faces one of its sternest tests of credibility. A resignation has left it lighter by a minister, but not yet lighter of conscience in the public eye.

Imagine an official brought to the limits of desperation by a minister allegedly resorting to the direst intimidation, including a threat at gunpoint, while demanding an out-of-turn decision. In his video, recorded at night before his suicide, Randhawa says fear had left him no other option, and named jails minister Laljit Bhullar as the source